DIPLOMA PROGRAMME PRACTICE / HL / SET A

Psychology / Paper 2

Worked mark scheme · 90 minutes · 35 marks

Answer all five questions. For Section A draw on the specified practical you conducted in class. For Section B, use the unseen study in this booklet.

Judge the whole response against the question-specific markband. Award zero for no creditworthy material. The worked answers illustrate one route; credit other scientifically defensible answers. Class-practical examples are illustrative.

SECTION A

Your class practical

QUESTION 1 / 4 MARKS

Describe the aim and procedure of the experiment that you took part in for your learning and cognition class practical.

Illustrative response. Suppose the class investigated whether retrieving definitions improves delayed recall compared with rereading them. Sixteen consenting volunteers first studied the same eight unfamiliar terms. Random allocation assigned eight to retrieve each definition and check feedback and eight to reread the definitions for the same time. A later test used the same prompts for everyone. An answer key fixed in advance gave one point per accurate definition. The aim, manipulation and recorded outcome identify what the experiment tested.

Marking a student's own practical. The response must describe the student's actual practical. Credit a different aim, design, sample and procedure when they are specific and consistent. Calling a method an experiment without identifying what was varied and what was measured does not demonstrate its use.

Markband. 1–2: some relevant method detail with gaps or imprecise terms. 3–4: accurate and specific methodological knowledge describes how the actual practical was conducted.

QUESTION 2 / 4 MARKS

Explain the concept of measurement in relation to the experiment you took part in.

Illustrative response. In the example, memory is a construct; the delayed definition score out of eight is its operational measure. The key makes scoring more consistent across markers, but a learner who recognises a definition yet cannot put it into words may receive zero. The score therefore reflects retrieval and verbal expression for these items, rather than every aspect of memory. The delay, cue and rule matter to the interpretation.

Marking a student's own practical. Reward a clear link from the student's construct to what was recorded and a consequence of that decision. An answer about a different operational measure can receive full marks. A generic definition of validity with no account of the class activity is weak application.

Markband. 1–2: a relevant concept with a limited link to the practical. 3–4: the concept is clearly explained through specific choices or findings in the actual practical.

QUESTION 3 / 6 MARKS

Compare and contrast the methodology of your class experiment with that of an observation investigating the same topic.

Illustrative response. Both could use agreed coding rules, the same learning period and consenting participants. In the experiment, the researcher assigns retrieval or rereading, holds study time constant and compares later scores. In a naturalistic observation the researcher could record which revision behaviours students already choose and how often they check answers. The observer does not assign the strategy. If confident students choose retrieval more often, the observation alone cannot isolate its effect.

Developing the comparison. Observation can capture ordinary combinations of strategies that the experiment separates. Awareness of being watched may alter either activity. An observation can be highly structured and an experiment can occur in a classroom; neither distinction is simply “qualitative versus quantitative”. Credit other paired similarities and differences linked to the student's actual method.

Markband. 1–2: brief or partly inaccurate comparisons. 3–4: similarities and differences receive uneven or partial explanation. 5–6: both are developed in a direct comparison using accurate research terminology.

QUESTION 4 / 6 MARKS

Design a semi-structured interview to investigate the same topic as your class experiment.

Illustrative design. For the retrieval example, recruit volunteers who have used both approaches. Speak individually in a quiet place, obtain consent for recording and allow skipping any question. Use the same neutral opening, such as “Talk me through how you prepared the definitions”, then ask for a particular occasion when a strategy did or did not help. Probe what “remembering” meant to that learner without presuming the quiz was beneficial.

From record to finding. Remove identifiers and compare coded accounts of cue use, confidence and delayed recall, keeping exceptions alongside frequent themes. A common interview guide makes cases comparable while follow-ups permit new meanings. The data address perceived processes; they cannot by themselves establish a causal improvement in test scores. Assess feasibility and the link to the chosen class topic.

Markband. 1–2: a method is named but its operation is unclear. 3–4: a workable outline lacks precision or connection to the aim. 5–6: a clear, detailed design uses the specified method appropriately to investigate the same topic.

SECTION B

Evaluation of an unseen study

QUESTION 5 / 15 MARKS

A college tested a voluntary workshop for adult apprentices on giving constructive feedback. Of 80 volunteers, 40 selected the first available evening and 40 joined a waiting list because that evening was inconvenient. Both groups rated their confidence on the same five items at entry. Their mean scores were similar. Workshop participants practised with a partner and received coaching; the waiting list continued its usual routine.

One week later, 36 workshop participants and 24 waiting-list participants completed the survey. Mean confidence among respondents rose by 1.2 points in the workshop group and 0.3 in the waiting-list group on a seven-point scale. The facilitator also scored a role-play, but only workshop attendees performed it and the facilitator knew them. A poster claimed that the workshop made apprentices more skilled in everyday disagreements. The research was constructed for this paper.

Discuss the study with reference to two or more of these concepts: causality, measurement, bias and responsibility.

Worked analysis. The waiting list gives a comparison over the same period and similar entry means make a large initial difference on the measured scale less plausible. Scheduling was self-selected, however. Shift patterns, time to practise or commitment could affect both attendance and later ratings. Follow-up retained 90% of the workshop group but 60% of the waiting list. Who returned may matter as much as the change in their mean; the 0.9-point contrast in reported gains is not automatically a treatment effect.

Linking concepts. Confidence is not the same construct as skill in a real disagreement. Repeating identical items helps comparability but a workshop can change what students understand a standard of competent feedback to mean. Role-play gives behavioural evidence for one group only, and an informed facilitator's expectations could bias ratings. A blinded assessor scoring the same task for both groups would address a measurement problem without removing the self-selection problem.

Reasoned appraisal. Random assignment among people available at the same time, an active comparison and comparable follow-up would strengthen a causal claim. Explain privacy and voluntary participation if using workplace feedback. It is reasonable to report improved confidence among respondents; the poster makes a broader claim about everyday skill that these observations do not settle. Different combinations of two or more offered concepts can earn full credit when grounded in the study.

Markband. 1–3: isolated comments or a minimal connection to the study. 4–6: relevant concepts are described with limited application. 7–9: study details support some analysis but links between concepts and methodological consequences are uneven. 10–12: developed, balanced evaluation relates at least two concepts to particular decisions and findings. 13–15: well-integrated concepts, accurate terminology and evidence produce a sustained critical evaluation and a justified judgement about this study.